

Lecture 13: Measuring performance

CMPE I20: Computer Organization & Architecture

Olivia Weng

Logistics

- Reminder: check-in with professor is 1% of your final grade
 - Sign up [link](#)
- HW2 due this today (!), October 1st, 11:59pm
- HW2 Quiz next Tuesday

Measure performance

- I want my program to run faster. I want it to speed up!

How to speed up a program?

- In the 1970s?

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 - Answer: Wait a year or two and buy a faster computer

Program's speed determined by computer speed

- Computer speed often determined by its clock frequency

Program's speed determined by computer speed

- Computer speed often determined by its clock frequency
- Clock frequency: number of CPU cycles per second
 - Measured in Hertz (1 / s)
 - Determines how much "work" a computer does per second

Back in the day...

- A CPU's **clock frequency** increased by **~30-50% every year**
- Higher clock frequency → more work done per second → program runs in less time!

Year	Clock Freq. (MHz)
1974	2
1978	5
1979	8

Example: Computing program latency

- Example program: GPT-2 takes 3 billion cycles to process 1 token
 - 3 billion = 3×10^9

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Year	Clock Freq. (MHz)	Program latency
1974	2	$1.5 \times 10^3 \text{ s} \approx 25 \text{ min}$
1978	5	$0.6 \times 10^3 \text{ s} \approx 10 \text{ min}$
1979	8	$0.375 \times 10^3 \text{ s} \approx 6.25 \text{ min}$

Let's run an experiment!

How did clock frequencies **increase** every couple years?

- Transistors got **smaller** year to year
- Cram **twice** as many transistors on **same-size CPU** every **~2 years**
 - Known as **Moore's Law**

How did clock frequencies **increase** every couple years?

- Transistors got **smaller** year to year
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 - Known as **Moore's Law**
- **Key:** Twice as many transistors → but **same power consumption**
 - Known as **Dennard Scaling**
 - Prevents chips from **overheating**

How did clock frequencies **increase** every couple years?

- A smaller transistor has a smaller **switching delay**
- **Switching delay** determines a CPU's clock frequency
 - Smaller delay → higher frequency!

How to speed up a program?

Dennard scaling let us increase clock frequencies every ~ 2 years at same power consumption

How to speed up a program?

Dennard scaling let us increase clock frequencies every ~ 2 years at same power consumption

- In the 1970s?
 - Answer: Wait a year or two and buy a faster computer
- In the 1980s?
- In the 1990s?
- In the 2000s?

Dennard Scaling ended around 2004-2005

- Voltage **stopped scaling down** with transistor size
 - Lowering it anymore caused transistors to **malfunction**

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Chips could **no longer** increase frequency **without overheating**

With the **end of Dennard Scaling**, how to **speed up** programs?

- In the 2000s?
- In the 2020s?

With the end of Dennard Scaling, how to speed up programs?

- Idea: Have multiple CPUs rather than a single CPU

Which programs benefit from multi-core computing?

Which programs do not benefit?

How much **speedup** can we get from multi-core?

- Not all parts of a program can be **parallelized**

How much **speedup** can we get from multi-core?

- Not all parts of a program can be **parallelized**
- Many programs have **serial** tasks

How much **speedup** can we get from multi-core?

Amdahl's law tells us the **speedup** we can get with **n** cores

- **speedup** = $\text{time_old} / \text{time_new}$
- given **p** percent of the program is parallelizable

The principle of Amdahl's Law

- By **Gene Amdahl** (one of the designers of IBM 360)
- Optimizations **do not** (generally) uniformly affect the entire program
 - The more **widely applicable** a optimization is, the more **valuable** it is
 - **Limited applicability** can (drastically) **reduce** the impact of an optimization

This the most important thing you will learn in this course!

Amdahl's Law Examples

Given a program that is 80% parallelizable, what is its speedup with

- 2 cores?
- 4 cores?
- 32 cores?

Amdahl's Law Examples

Given a program that is 80% parallelizable, what is its speedup with

- 2 cores? 1.67 X
- 4 cores? 2.5 X
- 32 cores? 4.4 X

Amdahl's Law gives us the **maximum speedup** of a program

- Using calculus...

Amdahl's Law Examples

What is the **maximum speedup** of a program that is

- 80% parallelizable?
- 50% parallelizable?
- 99% parallelizable?

Amdahl's Law Examples

What is the **maximum speedup** of a program that is

- 80% parallelizable? **5 X**
- 50% parallelizable? **2 X**
- 99% parallelizable? **100 X**

GPT-2 Present Day

- GPT-2 is **fast** now because it has big parallelizable portions
- CPU → GPU (ultra parallel processor)
- Why we can have a conversation with GPT in real-time

Is **faster** always better?

Match (best) performance metric to domain

- Performance Metrics

1. Network Bandwidth (MB/sec)
2. Network Latency (ms)
3. Frame Rate (frames/sec)
4. Throughput (ops/sec)

	Fortnite (online)	Call of Duty (single player)	Watching Netflix	Google Server Farm
A	4	3	1	2
B	4	1	3	2
C	2	1	3	4
D	2	3	1	4
E	None of the above			

References

- Hennessy, John L., and David A. Patterson. *Computer architecture: a quantitative approach*. Elsevier, 2025.
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- Inference characteristics of Llama. <https://cursor.com/blog/llama-inference>
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